Why We Revised the NYC School Survey Student Instrument

And What It Means for How You Read the Data

THE CASE FOR CHANGE

> For years, students, school leaders, and teachers told us the same thing: the survey was too long, too wordy, and written for adults — not the students completing it.

The NYC School Survey exists to amplify student voices. If students can't comfortably engage with the instrument — regardless of reading level or background — we aren't capturing their voices. We're capturing their confusion.

Summer 2025, the Survey Initiatives team acted on years of feedback and partnered directly with students, school leaders, teachers, researchers, and content experts to substantially revise and shorten the student instrument. Our goal: ensure that every student can comfortably engage with the survey.

OUR APPROACH

Central to our approach was prioritizing two key groups: school leaders who rely on the data for decision-making, and students who complete the survey. We used a ballot distributed to all eligible school leaders and survey coordinators, asking them to indicate which questions to keep, delete, or revise — and why. Over 300 responses came back. We deepened that input through listening sessions and cognitive interviews with students across all five boroughs.

STAKEHOLDER ENGAGEMENT

300+
Ballot responses from school leaders & coordinators

53
School leaders across 4 listening sessions

22
Students in cognitive interviews — all 5 boroughs, ages 11–18

Who Responded to the Ballot

39% Principals | 20% Assistant Principals | 14% School Staff | 4% Teachers

Student Voices Included

- 6 high school student leaders (4 of which are Chancellor Student Advisory Members)
- 16 students aged 11–14 at a Summer Rising site in Brooklyn

External Partners

- NYC Public Schools colleagues with relevant content expertise across divisions
- Research Alliance for NYC Schools (NYU Steinhardt): content validity review and equity measurement analysis

WHAT CHANGED AND WHY

MORE STUDENT-FRIENDLY LANGUAGE

- Simplified lengthy, abstract, and adult-oriented phrasing
- Revised language to be concrete and grounded in student experiences
- Shifted from agree/disagree scales to more direct question formats

ENHANCED ACTIONABILITY

- Adjusted questions to help educators design targeted solutions, not just diagnose
- Added frequency scales and counts to capture the scope of experiences
- Removed redundant questions and items outside the scope of school influence

WHAT WE PRESERVED

✓ Commitment to measuring equity in schools

✓ All core concepts and measures included in school-level reporting

✓ Alignment with existing school quality frameworks

A CLOSER LOOK: READING THE NEW DATA

Language changes can shift how students respond — not because reality in schools has changed, but because they are now answering more directly. Below is an example of a revised question, why it was changed, and how to interpret results this year.

PREVIOUS QUESTION

In how many of your classes are you encouraged to work in small groups?

NEW QUESTION

In how many of your classes do you work in small groups?

WHY WE CHANGED IT

When workshopping this question with students, they noted that "encouraged to work in small groups" was confusing. Students interpreted it differently — some wondered whether it meant an option or a strong suggestion. The intent was always to measure actual collaboration in classrooms, not opportunities to collaborate. The direct phrasing closes that gap and gives principals clearer, more actionable data.

⚠ HOW TO INTERPRET THIS YEAR'S RESULTS

You may notice lower favorability scores on some items compared to prior years. **This does not necessarily mean things got worse.** It often reflects students answering more directly and precisely under the new language — not a change in classroom reality.

Treat 2025–26 as a new baseline. Do not make year-over-year comparisons against prior student survey cycles for revised items.